dynasty rose to power, ruling until 1736. The Zand dynasty followed, and in 1779 the Qajar dynasty, which ruled until 1925, took over until the ascension of the Pahlavi dynasty.

The next insight we gained and processed over time was the hatred, contempt, and loathing that most Iranians feel toward Arab Muslims and other ethnic groups who adhere to the religion of Islam. This hatred originated in the second half of the eighth century, when the Muslims completed their conquest of Iran, destroying Iranian culture, eradicating the Zoroastrian religion that prevailed in Iran and forcibly converting the country's inhabitants to Islam, imposing the Arabic script while burning down Iranian libraries throughout the country, and "contaminating" the Iranian language with countless words from the Arabic language. The only ones to protest were the Iranian poets, who insisted on preserving the language and expressed their dissent through antiphrasis in their works. The poet Rudaki, who died in the year 941, was famous during the Samanid dynasty (819–1000), a period distinguished by an Iranian cultural renaissance. The poet Firdusi, who wrote the national epic work *Shahnameh* (Book of Kings), was the most prominent of that generation of poets; he died between 1020 and 1026.

Iran was Sunni until the early sixteenth century, when the founder of the Safavid dynasty, Ismail, decided to make Shia Islam the state religion. The reason for the change was the desire to distinguish Iran from its enemies, the Sunni Ottoman Empire and Uzbekistan in Central Asia.

The Iranians are proud of their Aryan origins. The shah's official title was "the Light of the Aryans." The syntax of the Persian language is very similar to that of German, and the language survived despite the Muslim conquest imposing the Arabic script. The Iranians consider themselves racially superior to the Muslims of the "inferior" Semitic race. The Iranian attitude toward the Arabs is one of contempt and racial superiority, as well as resentment over the Arab conquest and all that came with it.

An interesting question is: What preceded what in the Iranian experience? Did race precede religion or vice versa? Are Iranians' Aryan roots more significant for them than the religion of Islam in Iranians' sense of identity, or is it the other way around?

Historically speaking, the Muslim occupation of Iran led to the suppression and decline of the influence of the Zoroastrian religion that had prevailed in the territory of Persia but was ultimately unsuccessful in